WHAT DO WE ACTUALLY TAKE IN DURING THE DAY?

Working with the senses

By Ingrid van den Hout

Every day, we take in a lot through our senses. Not only what we drink and eat through our mouth or touch, but also anything that enters our eyes, ears or nose. The senses are the entrance to our awareness and can give rise to our automatic reactions: We find the experience either pleasant or unpleasant, and the next thing may be that we become aware that we really want this or really don't want that.

The home practice for this week is to pay attention to the senses every day and to notice what you do (or don't) hear, see, smell, feel and taste. The following questions can help you to notice:

- What is the source of what you take in through the senses?
- How much of it do you take in?
- Does it happen more or less automatically, or do you choose to become aware of something?
- How do you relate to it? Do you relate to it as neutral, pleasant or unpleasant?
- How does your body react to it? And your breath? Any thoughts and feelings?
- How do you relate to what you take in?

Tasting: What do you actually eat? And what do you drink on a given day?
Spend a day noticing which moments you eat and drink.
Are your choices conscious or automatic?
Are you aware of the taste?
Are there any thoughts and emotions connected to eating and drinking?
Do you notice the effect of food and drinks on the body?

Source: MBSR Participant Workbook, Institute for Mindfulness, Rolde, The Netherlands Credit: Johan Tinge, Director, and Ingrid van den Hout, Faculty Member

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Hearing: During the day there are a great variety of sounds.
Which sounds do you notice, which sounds pass by unnoticed?
Which sounds are pleasant, which onces are neutral or unpleasant?
Are these feelings (pleasant, neutral, unpleasant) connected to certain thoughts and emotions?
Do sounds have an effect on the body?

Seeing: What do you see, what enters your eyes? And what is it you don't see?

Examples:

- Nature or city sights
- Things in your house
- Other people
- The image of your body in the mirror
- Images on television and the internet
- Texts from books, newspapers or magazines
- Works of art
- Waste products

Do you notice any preferences? Any aversion?

Smelling: What do you smell, which scents enter your nose?

Examples: Smells of your own body… of others …

- In your house
- Of food and drinks
- In nature
- In the city

Touching: What do you sense with your

- hands,
- feet,
- skin at any part of the body?

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